

VE Opening v. Apple Inc.

Apple iOS/iPadOS Spotlight system-level search and cross-application linking under U.S. Patent No. 10,635,293.

Independent preliminary research based on public information.

FILED	FORUM	DOCKET	MATTER
2026-08-21	W.D. Tex.	7:26-cv-00331	Patent Infringement

Prepared 2026-08-25. No attorney or expert contacted. Availability, interest, compensation, and conflicts not checked.

Public filing, likely recipient, and technical frame

CAPTION	VE Opening LLC v. Apple Inc.
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FORUM / DOCKET	W.D. Tex. / 7:26-cv-00331
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FILED / TYPE	2026-08-21 / patent infringement
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PUBLIC DOCKET	Open docket
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VERIFIED PUBLIC RECORD

VE Opening LLC v. Apple Inc., No. 7:26-cv-00331, filed 2026-08-21 in W.D. Tex..

LIKELY RESEARCH PURCHASER

Steven G. Kalberg - Direction IP Law; named matter counsel. The individual docket identifies Kalberg as the complaint filer and plaintiff counsel. Selecting the opening filer as the likely early technical-research purchaser is an analytical inference.

skalberg@directionip.com - publicly listed on the [official firm biography](#); not inferred.

TECHNICAL FRAME

Apple iOS/iPadOS Spotlight system-level search and cross-application linking under U.S. Patent No. 10,635,293.

Secondary-source limitation: This is a preliminary technical frame based on public sources. Filed pleadings, claim charts, discovery, source code, product versions, and admissible evidence must control. [Open public synopsis](#)

REPORTED ASSERTED PATENTS

[U.S. 10,635,293](#)

Questions likely to require expert input

This issue map is a research plan, not a legal conclusion. The filed complaint, patent exhibits, intrinsic record, and discovery must control.

01 Claim mapping and accused operation

Claim mapping and accused operation: Whether Spotlight builds and queries system indexes, ranks heterogeneous results, constructs cross-application links, and performs each asserted limitation across relevant iOS/iPadOS versions.

Potential evidence: Pleadings and claim charts; source code or engineering records; product and version documentation; standards and prior art; reproducible testing; and fact or technical testimony as applicable.

02 Technical meaning and ordinary skill

Technical meaning and ordinary skill: what would a person of ordinary skill have understood the asserted computing, media, networking, or telephony terms to mean at the relevant priority dates?

Potential evidence: Pleadings and claim charts; source code or engineering records; product and version documentation; standards and prior art; reproducible testing; and fact or technical testimony as applicable.

03 Architecture and causation

Architecture and causation: which device, client, server, network element, or code module performs each claimed step, in what order, and under what configurations?

Potential evidence: Pleadings and claim charts; source code or engineering records; product and version documentation; standards and prior art; reproducible testing; and fact or technical testimony as applicable.

04 Versioning and proof

Versioning and proof: which source-code branches, protocol traces, media samples, configuration records, test captures, and product versions are needed for reproducible analysis?

Potential evidence: Pleadings and claim charts; source code or engineering records; product and version documentation; standards and prior art; reproducible testing; and fact or technical testimony as applicable.

Questions likely to require expert input

05 Validity and technical contribution

Validity and technical contribution: what dated publications, standards, patents, products, and implementations disclose the claimed elements, and what technical value is attributable to the claimed combination rather than conventional components?

Potential evidence: Pleadings and claim charts; source code or engineering records; product and version documentation; standards and prior art; reproducible testing; and fact or technical testimony as applicable.

Candidates 1-2 for further diligence

Ranked for preliminary research priority based on subject-matter fit, relevant public work, testimony, and visible diligence burden. This is not a retention recommendation.

01 Marti Hearst

Professor, UC Berkeley School of Information and EECS

TECHNICAL FIT

Search engines, information retrieval, search-user interfaces, and information-rich interface design. For VE Opening LLC v. Apple Inc., the fit is specifically Apple Spotlight indexing, system-level search, deep links, cross-application result presentation, and the boundary between OS search infrastructure and app-provided metadata.

RELEVANT WORK

Author of Search User Interfaces, the first academic book devoted to that subject. Research spans search engines, information retrieval, computational linguistics, and information visualization.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific public expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial-testimony record for Marti Hearst was located in a bounded public-web search. This is not proof that the candidate has never served in litigation; PACER, paid expert databases, retention records, and conflict systems were not searched.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Best suited to retrieval architecture, ranking, and search interaction; not a mobile-OS reverse engineer or multimedia transport specialist. Matter-specific diligence should also test independence from the parties, patents, accused products, and counsel; no conflict clearance has been performed.

[Source 1](#) | [Source 2](#)

[Draft email](#) | hearst@berkeley.edu | [public email source](#)

02 ChengXiang Zhai

Donald Biggar Willett Professor, Siebel School of Computing and Data Science, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

TECHNICAL FIT

Information retrieval, intelligent information systems, ranking, text analysis, and user simulation. For VE Opening LLC v. Apple Inc., the fit is specifically Apple Spotlight indexing, system-level search, deep links, cross-application result presentation, and the boundary between OS search infrastructure and app-provided metadata.

RELEVANT WORK

Coauthor of Text Data Management: A Practical Introduction to Information Retrieval and Text Mining. Research includes intelligent search engines, recommender systems, chatbots, and retrieval models.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific public expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial-testimony record for ChengXiang Zhai was located in a bounded public-web search. This is not proof that the candidate has never served in litigation; PACER, paid expert databases, retention records, and conflict systems were not searched.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Strong on retrieval algorithms and system behavior, but less directly focused on iOS internals, multimedia container formats, or handset forensics. Matter-specific diligence should also test independence from the parties, patents, accused products, and counsel; no conflict clearance has been performed.

[Source 1](#) | [Source 2](#)

[Draft email](#) | czhai@illinois.edu | [public email source](#)

Candidates 3-4 for further diligence

03 Ricardo Baeza-Yates

Visiting Full Professor, Khoury College of Computer Sciences, Northeastern University

TECHNICAL FIT

Web search, data mining, information retrieval algorithms, and industrial search-system leadership. For VE Opening LLC v. Apple Inc., the fit is specifically Apple Spotlight indexing, system-level search, deep links, cross-application result presentation, and the boundary between OS search infrastructure and app-provided metadata.

RELEVANT WORK

Coauthor of Modern Information Retrieval and more than 600 publications. Former vice president of research at Yahoo Labs and CTO of semantic-search company NTENT.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific public expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial-testimony record for Ricardo Baeza-Yates was located in a bounded public-web search. This is not proof that the candidate has never served in litigation; PACER, paid expert databases, retention records, and conflict systems were not searched.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

His strongest fit is search and ranking at system scale, not source-code analysis of Apple frameworks or media protocol implementation. Matter-specific diligence should also test independence from the parties, patents, accused products, and counsel; no conflict clearance has been performed.

[Source 1](#)

[Draft email](#) | r.baeza-yates@northeastern.edu | [public email source](#)

04 Steve Whittaker

Professor Emeritus of Computational Media, University of California, Santa Cruz

TECHNICAL FIT

Human-computer interaction, digital communication, collaboration, personal information management, and social networks. For VE Opening LLC v. Apple Inc., the fit is specifically Apple Spotlight indexing, system-level search, deep links, cross-application result presentation, and the boundary between OS search infrastructure and app-provided metadata.

RELEVANT WORK

Researches computational tools for communication, collaboration, memory, and personal information management. Recipient of a SIGCHI Lifetime Research Achievement Award and author of work on email and communication overload.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific public expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial-testimony record for Steve Whittaker was located in a bounded public-web search. This is not proof that the candidate has never served in litigation; PACER, paid expert databases, retention records, and conflict systems were not searched.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Primarily a human-use and interaction expert; would need pairing with a source-code or protocol expert for implementation-level infringement analysis. Matter-specific diligence should also test independence from the parties, patents, accused products, and counsel; no conflict clearance has been performed.

[Source 1](#) | [Source 2](#)

[Draft email](#) | swhittak@ucsc.edu | [public email source](#)

Candidates 5-6 for further diligence

05 Karrie Karahalios

Professor, Siebel School of Computing and Data Science, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

TECHNICAL FIT

Sociable-media design, computer-mediated communication, social-network analysis, and interactive systems. For VE Opening LLC v. Apple Inc., the fit is specifically Apple Spotlight indexing, system-level search, deep links, cross-application result presentation, and the boundary between OS search infrastructure and app-provided metadata.

RELEVANT WORK

Research focus includes sociable media design, assistive communication technologies, and cues in networked environments. Publishes in CHI, CSCW, UIST, and SIGMOD on social and interactive computing.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific public expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial-testimony record for Karrie Karahalios was located in a bounded public-web search. This is not proof that the candidate has never served in litigation; PACER, paid expert databases, retention records, and conflict systems were not searched.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Better suited to communication flows and user-facing behavior than low-level indexing, codec, or transport implementation. Matter-specific diligence should also test independence from the parties, patents, accused products, and counsel; no conflict clearance has been performed.

[Source 1](#) | [Source 2](#)

[Draft email](#) | kkarahal@illinois.edu | [public email source](#)

06 Jeffrey Heer

Jerre D. Noe Professor of Computer Science & Engineering, University of Washington

TECHNICAL FIT

Interactive systems, scalable data transformation, visualization, and human-computer interaction. For VE Opening LLC v. Apple Inc., the fit is specifically Apple Spotlight indexing, system-level search, deep links, cross-application result presentation, and the boundary between OS search infrastructure and app-provided metadata.

RELEVANT WORK

Co-created Vega, Vega-Lite, D3.js, and Mosaic; co-founded Trifacta. Research papers have won awards at CHI, UIST, CSCW, IUI, IEEE VIS, and VAST.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific public expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial-testimony record for Jeffrey Heer was located in a bounded public-web search. This is not proof that the candidate has never served in litigation; PACER, paid expert databases, retention records, and conflict systems were not searched.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Strong on interaction and data systems, but not principally a mobile operating-system, telephony, or video-streaming specialist. Matter-specific diligence should also test independence from the parties, patents, accused products, and counsel; no conflict clearance has been performed.

[Source 1](#)

[Draft email](#) | jheer@cs.washington.edu | [public email source](#)

Candidates 7-8 for further diligence

07 Ed H. Chi

Distinguished Scientist and Senior Lead, Google DeepMind

TECHNICAL FIT

Industrial search, recommendation, dialog systems, social computing, and large-scale user-behavior modeling. For VE Opening LLC v. Apple Inc., the fit is specifically Apple Spotlight indexing, system-level search, deep links, cross-application result presentation, and the boundary between OS search infrastructure and app-provided metadata.

RELEVANT WORK

Google profile reports more than 420 product improvements and 39 patents. Led work on YouTube recommendation, Google Play search and discovery, dialog models, and social search.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific public expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial-testimony record for Ed H. Chi was located in a bounded public-web search. This is not proof that the candidate has never served in litigation; PACER, paid expert databases, retention records, and conflict systems were not searched.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Current industry affiliation may create conflicts or access constraints; expertise is broad and product-facing rather than Apple-specific. Matter-specific diligence should also test independence from the parties, patents, accused products, and counsel; no conflict clearance has been performed.

[Source 1](#) | [Source 2](#)

[Draft email](#) | chi@acm.org | [public email source](#)

08 Jeff Hancock

Harry and Norman Chandler Professor of Communication and Director, Stanford Social Media Lab

TECHNICAL FIT

Online communication, social-media behavior, language, trust, and user mental models of algorithms. For VE Opening LLC v. Apple Inc., the fit is specifically Apple Spotlight indexing, system-level search, deep links, cross-application result presentation, and the boundary between OS search infrastructure and app-provided metadata.

RELEVANT WORK

Founding director of Stanford Social Media Lab and co-director of the Cyber Policy Center. Published more than 100 articles on online interaction, language, deception, trust, and social media.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific public expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial-testimony record for Jeff Hancock was located in a bounded public-web search. This is not proof that the candidate has never served in litigation; PACER, paid expert databases, retention records, and conflict systems were not searched.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Primarily a communication and behavioral scientist, not an implementation expert for search indexes, codecs, or mobile source code. Matter-specific diligence should also test independence from the parties, patents, accused products, and counsel; no conflict clearance has been performed.

[Source 1](#) | [Source 2](#)

[Draft email](#) | hancockj@stanford.edu | [public email source](#)

Candidates 9-10 for further diligence

09 Nick Feamster

Neubauer Professor of Computer Science and Faculty Director of Research, Data Science Institute, University of Chicago

TECHNICAL FIT

Internet measurement, video technologies, software-defined networking, privacy, and deployed network systems. For VE Opening LLC v. Apple Inc., the fit is specifically Apple Spotlight indexing, system-level search, deep links, cross-application result presentation, and the boundary between OS search infrastructure and app-provided metadata.

RELEVANT WORK

Built early live-television-over-Internet systems and researches network performance and security. His official homepage states experience as an expert witness in software patent, copyright, trade-secret, privacy, and other technology litigation, including federal trial testimony.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

Official University of Chicago homepage states that he serves as an expert witness in technology litigation and has federal trial-testimony experience in software patent, copyright, trade-secret, privacy, and related matters.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Broad systems expert rather than a narrow specialist in a particular codec, Apple framework, or telephony switch; active expert practice requires careful conflicts diligence. Matter-specific diligence should also test independence from the parties, patents, accused products, and counsel; no conflict clearance has been performed.

[Source 1](#) | [Source 2](#)

[Draft email](#) | feamster@uchicago.edu | [public email source](#)

10 Pablo César

Group Leader, Distributed and Interactive Systems, CWI; Professor, TU Delft

TECHNICAL FIT

Distributed interactive media, real-time communication, media-object control, multimedia systems, and quality of experience. For VE Opening LLC v. Apple Inc., the fit is specifically Apple Spotlight indexing, system-level search, deep links, cross-application result presentation, and the boundary between OS search infrastructure and app-provided metadata.

RELEVANT WORK

Leads CWI research on complex collections of media objects distributed in time and space. Work on multiparty real-time communication, volumetric video, compression, and delivery has entered MPEG and ITU processes.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific public expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial-testimony record for Pablo César was located in a bounded public-web search. This is not proof that the candidate has never served in litigation; PACER, paid expert databases, retention records, and conflict systems were not searched.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Most direct fit is distributed interactive media and user experience, not OS kernel internals, classic information retrieval, or patent-priority historical analysis. Matter-specific diligence should also test independence from the parties, patents, accused products, and counsel; no conflict clearance has been performed.

[Source 1](#)

[Draft email](#) | P.S.Cesar@cwi.nl | [public email source](#)

Preliminary candidates; no conflicts or availability determination

- Run party, affiliate, counsel, inventor, funder, and technology conflicts.
- Confirm testimony history, exclusions, compensation, publications, patents, and deposition performance.
- Investigate licensing, grants, consulting, commercial interests, and prior technical positions.
- Confirm role fit, availability, and interest only after counsel authorizes outreach.

ONGOING MATTER-SPECIFIC RESEARCH

Flint Witness Research works in the post-filing window, turning pleadings and public technical records into issue maps, researched candidate slates, and diligence starting points as the case develops.

[Schedule a 15-minute conversation](#)

CORE SOURCES

Public docket: <https://dockets.justia.com/docket/texas/txwdce/7%3A2026cv00331/1172929055>

Official attorney biography and email: <https://ai-lab.exparte.com/attorney/6517108/steven-g-kalberg>

Public technical context source: <https://ai-lab.exparte.com/case/dct/txwd/7%3A26-cv-00331/doc/analysis/1>

LIMITATIONS

This is a preliminary technical frame based on public sources. Filed pleadings, claim charts, discovery, source code, product versions, and admissible evidence must control.

No attorney or expert was contacted. Availability, interest, compensation, and conflicts were not checked.